

23 MULTICULTURAL SOCIETY AND INTERNATIONAL INSTITUTIONS (the EU and NATO)



To live anywhere in the world today and be against equality because of race or color, is like living in Alaska and being against snow.

William Faulkner

When in Rome, do as the Romans do.

English idiom

□ VOCABULARY INPUT

Dealing with this topic you will come across the following vocabulary. Read it and look up the unknown words in your dictionary.

- **multiculturalism:** “cultural mosaic”, acceptance, appreciation, promotion of multiple cultures, tolerance, respect for diversity, dual citizenship, bicultural person, interaction of cultures, negative impact: native culture disappearance
- **assimilation:** “melting pot” – mixing and integrating diverse cultural groups, keeping cultural identity, preserving culture and religion, cultural uniqueness, cultural safety, the status of minorities and immigrants
- **common reasons for migration:** bicultural marriages, brain drain, job opportunities, study exchange, search for freedom and a better life
- **immigrants:** possible cultural adaptation by learning the language, making new contacts, finding a job, getting a new qualification
- **minorities:** ethnic, racial, religious
- **discrimination:** sexual, racial, religious, ethnic prejudices against somebody
- **xenophobia, racism:** incidents, riots, violent clashes, racist attacks, protests
- **international institutions:**
 - *the European Union* (the European Council, the European Commission, the European Parliament, the Court of Human Rights, the Court of Justice, the Court of Auditors)
 - *NATO* (North Atlantic Treaty Organisation), intergovernmental military alliance, collective/mutual defence, protection, support, NATO headquarters, member states

□ DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Before reading the text, discuss the following questions in class.

1. Which countries/cities/megacities do you think are multicultural? Why?
2. Is your country multicultural?
3. What are the rights of minorities living in Slovakia?
4. What is your reaction: An African-American man and a Slovak woman dating each other?

5. What prejudices do people have against the Roma minority living in Slovakia?
6. Why is it dangerous to create stereotypes?
7. Would you like to live in a neighbourhood with the Roma minority? Explain.
8. If you were an immigrant in a foreign country, would you try to adjust to the culture there? How?
9. Why do people migrate from country to country?
10. What is the future of multiculturalism in the world?

□ TEXT

Read the texts below in silence. Check the meaning of the words in bold and answer the questions below.

MULTICULTURALISM VS. CULTURAL ASSIMILATION

The term multiculturalism describes a society **composed of** different cultural groups which create a “cultural mosaic”. Cultural groups living in a multicultural society try to **preserve** their **unique** cultures. Cultural differences are **mutually** respected and tolerated. This is the official policy of Canada, Australia and the UK. The United Kingdom receives a large number of immigrants every year; London has become a true cosmopolitan city. Canada is known for its English-French bilingualism but is **selective** about who may enter the country and who may not. Multiculturalism includes **dual citizenship**, use of **minority** languages and support of their culture and religion.

Many people think that multiculturalism can destroy the national **sovereignty** of the country and they prefer the idea of a “**melting pot**” that mixes and integrates different cultural groups. These countries **aim at** the social integration of immigrant groups into the national culture. This is called cultural assimilation and it is **in contrast to** multiculturalism. A typical example of a “melting pot” is the USA, often celebrated for its multicultural **diversity**. Immigrants preserve their own culture and family background while also becoming Americans. Assimilation can sometimes have a negative **impact** on national minorities – in extreme cases, the **distinctive features** of their original culture can become **diluted** or even disappear.

1. What are typical features of a multicultural society?
2. How is assimilation in contrast to multiculturalism?

IMMIGRANTS, XENOPHOBIA AND RACISM

Cultural adaptation is difficult when immigrants have to adapt to completely different cultural **values** or to a religion. A **lack of** cultural integration (**due to** the immigrants themselves or because of the **host country**) can cause the isolation of immigrant minorities. This can provoke xenophobia and racism which can **lead to** serious **incidents**. **Urban violence** in France in 2005 caused by frustration among **ethnic** minorities over racism and unemployment is an example. In 2006, there were a series of protests in different

Muslim countries against the Mohammed Cartoons published in Danish newspapers. The publication of these caricatures provoked a **clash** between the Muslim world (which felt its religion was under attack) and the West (which felt freedom of speech was under attack). In 2009, the French government **proposed** a new law connected with Muslim women wearing full-face **veils** called “burkas” in public places. The authorities expressed their opinion that burkas were not welcome in their country. The argument is about whether Muslim women are willing to give up their traditions and adapt to the culture of their host country and **submit to** their laws. Are similar rules dictated to immigrants in host countries **in accordance with** democracy and their **constitutions**? Should minorities or immigrants accept the saying that “when in Rome, do as the Romans do”? Where are the limits for **mutual acceptance** and understanding of diverse cultures, religions and traditions in multicultural society?

3. Using the information from the text above, name some incidents caused by a lack of cultural and religion tolerance in the world.
4. Explain the saying “When in Rome, do as the Romans do” in relation to multiculturalism.

CREATING STEREOTYPES AND PREJUDICE IN SLOVAKIA

The majority of the Slovak population are Slovak. The country also has several minorities, the biggest of which are Hungarian, **Roma**, **Ruthenian** and **Ukrainian**. A minority can be defined as an ethnic, **racial**, religious or other group forming a **whole** and different from the **majority** of the population in a country. The Roma population in Slovakia has found it difficult to adapt and is often the **victim** of racist attacks. There exist a number of projects to **facilitate** the integration of this ethnic group into society. The Roma population is encouraged to attend schools and complete compulsory education, care more about their personal hygiene and find employment. **State benefits** provided to Roma people are given on condition that they do **voluntary** work which aims to encourage Roma people to look for jobs instead of staying unemployed. The attitude of young Slovaks towards minorities is often shaped by their parents, who provide them with **stereotypes** and **prejudice**. The International Gypsy Multicultural Festival organised annually in Slovakia is a special multicultural event dedicated to all “Gypsies” from segregated and separated areas in Slovakia. Its aim is to fight against racism and xenophobia and show the majority population the cultural richness and traditions of Roma people **via** their musical performances, theatre workshops, photo exhibitions and films about Roma culture. This type of project might change **negative attitudes towards** minorities in Slovakia.

5. Which minorities live in Slovakia?
6. How is the Roma minority in Slovakia encouraged to integrate?

LEAVING THE COUNTRY – CURRENT TREND?

Since 1989, quite a lot of Slovaks have been leaving the country to find a better-paid job elsewhere in Western Europe, the USA and Canada. In 2004, Slovakia became a part of a larger community – the European Union. Some countries, such as the United Kingdom

and Sweden, decided to open up their **labour market** to workers from the 10 countries which had just joined the EU. Some other countries **imposed** so called “labour market **restrictions**”, which allow Slovaks to work there only in certain **fields** under certain conditions. Some of them will gradually open up their labour markets in the near future. Slovakia has also received immigrants from other countries. Not many of them stay in Slovakia; the majority wants to move to Germany or other western European countries. Many highly-qualified people leave the country due to a lack of job opportunities. They go to a host country which is seen to have a developed economy, political stability and freedom. This is called a “**brain drain**”.

7. What is meant by “labour market restrictions”?

8. What is meant by “brain drain”?

CULTURAL EXCHANGES AND THEIR BENEFITS

Thanks to open **borders**, Slovaks have also been travelling much more than before. They have been learning foreign languages and **discovering** new cultures. Cultural **exchanges** are usually very **beneficial** and they can change people's lives in very positive ways. People learn about other cultures, find new friends, get more tolerant and **realise** that difference is positive and not something they should be afraid of. There are Slovaks who have decided to stay abroad; a lot of them have got married in a foreign country, creating **bicultural** families. They try to adapt to the foreign culture they find themselves in as soon as possible – learn the language, make new contacts, find a job and sometimes get a new qualification.

9. Why are cultural exchanges beneficial according to the text above?

10. What are possible ways of adapting to a foreign culture?

□ VOCABULARY LIST

to aim at – zamerať sa na

beneficial – osožný, prospešný

bicultural [baɪkʌltʃərəl] – bikultúrny

border – hranica, pohraničie

brain drain – únik mozgov

clash – konflikt, zrážka

composed of – zložený z

constitution – ústava

cultural adaptation – kultúrne prispôbenie sa

to dilute [daɪ'l(j)u:t] – oslabiť, rozdrobiť

to discover – objaviť

distinctive feature [dɪ'stɪŋktɪv fi:tʃə(r)] – typická vlastnosť

diversity [daɪ'vɜ:səti] – rozmanitosť

dual citizenship – dvojité občianstvo

due to [dju: tə] – spôsobený

ethnic [əθnɪk] – etnický

exchange – výmena

to facilitate – uľahčiť

field – oblasť, odbor

host country – hostiteľská krajina

impact – dopad

incident [ɪn'sɪdənt] – incident, udalosť

labour market – trh práce

lack of – nedostatok

to lead to – viesť k

majority [mə'dʒɔrəti] – väčšina

melting pot – „taviaci kotol“ (prenesený význam: miesto, kde sa zmiešavajú rôzne kultúry)

minority [maɪ'nɔrəti] – menšina

mutual acceptance – vzájomné tolerovanie, akceptácia

mutually [mju:tʃʊəli] – vzájomne

prejudice [prədʒʊdɪs] – predsudok

to preserve – zachovať, uchovať

to propose – navrhnúť

racial – rasový

to realise [rɪəlaɪz] – uvedomiť si

Roma [rəʊmə] – rómsky

Ruthenian [rʊθenɪən] – rusínsky

selective – výberový

sovereignty [sɒvrəntɪ] – zvrchovanosť

state benefit – štátna podpora

stereotype – stereotyp

to submit to – podrobiť sa

Ukrainian – ukrajinský

unique [juˈni:k] – jedinečný

urban violence – násilie v meste

value – hodnota

veil [veɪl] – závoj

via [vaɪə] – prostredníctvom

victim – obeť

voluntary – dobrovoľný

whole [həʊl] – celok

to impose restrictions [ɪmˈpəʊz rɪˈstrɪkʃnz]
– zaviesť/uložiť obmedzenia

in accordance with – v súlade s

in contrast to – na rozdiel od

negative attitudes towards – negatívne postoje k

□ VOCABULARY PRACTICE

Task 1 In the list below there are some countries which are not members of the European Union. Find them and cross them out. Can you say which countries formed the EU at the very beginning of its existence and which countries joined later? Check on the Internet.

The Czech Republic – Turkey – Slovakia – Hungary – Poland – Latvia – Norway – Lithuania – Estonia – Malta – Slovenia – Croatia – Cyprus – Belgium – Germany – France – Italy – Luxembourg – the Netherlands – Bulgaria – Greece – Spain – Portugal – Austria – Switzerland – Finland – Sweden

Task 2 The names of countries and languages are written incorrectly in the text. Correct them.



Germany

I went on holiday to ~~German~~ last year where I met some really interesting people.

The first one was Mario: He was an Italy but we spoke England together. He was really intelligent and could speak Hungary and Spain, but he didn't know any Slovakia.

My other great friend there was Isabelle. She was France, but her mother was Pole so she could understand most of what I said. The three of us had a great time. We went

to see a Russia film and then had a Greece meal. We're hoping to meet again next year in Dutch or maybe Irish.